xxx – Salutation – xxx

Assalamualaikum warahmatullahi wabarakatuh and good morning.

A warm welcome to everyone here today, especially to those joining us for the first time. It is truly a privilege for UCSI University to host the 2026 Education Malaysia Global Services Townhall.

We are meeting at a time when Malaysia's international education landscape is gaining strong momentum. As of 2025, Malaysia is home to approximately 170,000 international students, a 63 percent increase since mid-2023. These numbers represent the growing confidence in our institution and in Malaysia as a whole. More importantly, this brings us closer to the government's ambition of welcoming 250,000 international students in the years ahead.

At UCSI, we are proud to contribute to this ecosystem. We currently host over 5,500 international students from more than 90 countries, with over 3000 graduates in the past three years alone. This diversity is a strong reflection of Malaysia's global reach and reinforces the importance of having a well-coordinated system to support international students.

Supporting international students today requires more than isolated efforts. It requires strong alignment between institutions and government agencies. Universities, such as ours, guide students through their academic journeys and campus life, while government bodies provide the structure through immigration policies, healthcare systems and safety frameworks. When these efforts are aligned, students experience a smoother, more supportive journey that allows them to focus on what brought them here in the first place - their education and personal growth.

Malaysia's appeal as a study destination is clear. We are a multicultural society where diversity is part of daily life. English is widely used as the medium of instruction, making adaptation easier. At the same time, we offer a high quality of life within a relatively affordable environment, along with access to globally recognised qualifications at competitive costs. These strengths are reflected in global recognition, with Kuala Lumpur ranked 12th in the QS Best Student Cities Rankings 2026.

This success is strengthened through the collaboration between EMGS and higher education institutions. EMGS plays an important role as a centralised one-stop centre, allowing universities to focus on education while ensuring efficient management of international student processes.

Today, visa processing has significantly improved, with approvals taking as little as 14 working days, and in some cases even 8 to 10 days. In fact, during peak periods, EMGS is able to manage between 14 to 15 thousand applications each month. This level of efficiency is only made possible through strong digital integration between EMGS and institutions, ensuring transparency, speed and consistency. At the same time, enhancements such as direct applications for mobility students reflect a more flexible and responsive system.

Ladies and gentlemen,

We must also recognise the broader global context in which we operate. Today's student mobility landscape is increasingly shaped by geopolitical uncertainties and fluctuating power dynamics. Ongoing tensions in key regions are influencing how students and families make decisions about where to study.

In such uncertain times, stability, safety and reliability is absolutely crucial to decision-making.

This presents a clear opportunity for Malaysia. We are seen as stable, accessible and welcoming. A country that offers quality education without unnecessary barriers. A place where students from different regions can come together and feel at home with confidence.

We must seize this moment to further strengthen our position as a leading global education hub.

As we begin today's townhall session, I encourage all of us to exchange ideas openly and explore how we can continue to improve together. Thank you to all stakeholders for your continued dedication and support. Your contributions are important in shaping the future of international education in Malaysia.

With that, I wish everyone a productive and fruitful session.

Thank you.